He remembers watching black and white classics such as *Do Bigha Zamin* and *Kabuliwala*, films that, decades later, still remain fresh. The commercial cinema of the nineties, he says, "made the *mahaul* rotten". Yet his faith in cinema remained. "Life is a big leveller," he says. "You might need time, but slowly and gradually you generally get what you desire and what truly belongs to you."

Yadav sees something similar in the rise of OTT, which has given character actors more room to breathe. Good scripts existed before, he says, "but everybody never really got a chance." *Panchayat*, for him, represents what happens when theatre-trained actors are finally given that space. "Theatre teaches you to do your homework well," he says, and its discipline is "humongous". There are no retakes on stage; preparation has to be lived before the performance.

Yadav is drawn to stories like *Om Ka Hari* that are "*hatke*" (different), carrying the diversity of Indian life beyond commercial formulas. Perhaps that instinct comes from his beginnings. "I come from a village [in Jabalpur], where I used to ride a bullock cart. I never thought that one day I would become an actor." Initially, he was drawn to music. "Then came the village performances of Ram Leela and Ras Leela. Films came much later while I was already learning the craft." Perhaps that is why Yadav was never in a hurry. He has spent a lifetime watching, absorbing, becoming the characters he played. And as he puts it, simply: "*Har zindagi ka mazaa lena hai mujhe* [I want to enjoy many different lives]." ■

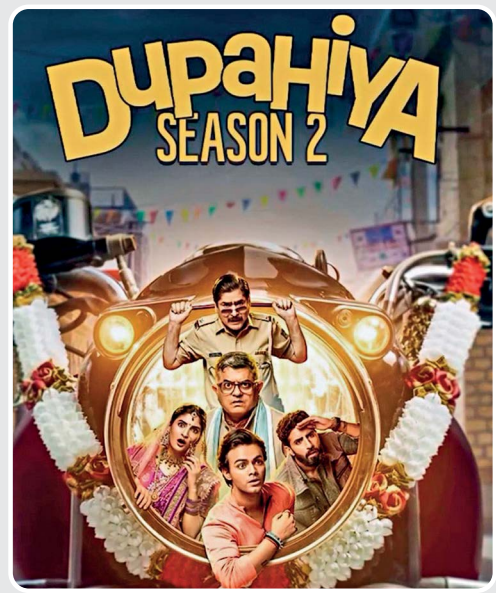
— Lachmi Deb Roy

OTT ▼

The Village Has More Stories

AMAZON PRIME VIDEO'S VILLAGE COMEDY *DUPAHIYA* RETURNS FOR A SECOND SEASON WITH A FRESH SET OF SOCIAL THEMES

Getting greenlit for season two instantly after the release of season one is an undeniable stamp of approval. Delivering it within 18 months—unheard of in the streaming circuit—is an even bigger accomplishment. *Dupahiya*, whose season 2 landed on Amazon Prime Video on October 1, does just that as it looks to build its own *Panchayat*-like following with its village setting, vibrant characters and relatable issues.



Bhuvan Arora, who plays Amavas, says he knew the "sweet, warm" story set in the fictional village of Dhadakpur would find an audience. "The biggest accomplishment for an actor is when audiences call you by your character's name," says Bhuvan. Alongside him, the cast includes Shivani Raghuvanshi (*Tithi*, *Made in Heaven*) and Sparsh Shrivastava (*Jamtara*, *Laapataa Ladies*), who play the Jha siblings, Roshni and Bhugol. The trio is proof of how OTT has given opportunity and recognition to talented actors. "It's definitely levelled the field," says Sparsh. "Star or newcomer, a story can lift you up; all you need is talent."

While the first season touched on issues like insecurity and scrutiny over dark skin, patriarchy, dowry and desperation to move to the city, the new season, says Bhuvan, will continue to highlight new ones without getting preachy. "I feel when you are making a story set in a village, it becomes easier for you to talk about issues," adds Shivani. "With city settings, we still have to project an image, pretend that one's woke and balance the characters."

For Sparsh, who drew appreciation for his uninhibited '*launda naach*' (where men cross-dress as women) on the show, season two gives his character more depth. "The arc has become better, more emotional," he says. And yes, there's more dancing this time, with a routine choreographed by Kruti Mahesh.

The actors remain tight-lipped on a possible season three. Bhuvan certainly would love to have another go at it. "With season one, we set the benchmark, so there's more responsibility to deliver in two," he says. "The burden is on the writers and creators. I am sure they have started thinking of a story." ■

—Suhani Singh